

Setting up a campaign in SendKit

A campaign is three jobs done in order: get a clean, validated lead list in, write a sequence that reads like a person wrote it, then launch and let the schedule do the pacing. Here is the whole flow.

1. Import and validate your leads

- **Three ways in:** CSV upload (upload, map columns, done), CRM sync (HubSpot, Pipedrive, Salesforce, Zoho, or GHL), or push leads programmatically via the API. No list yet? SendKit's lead database has over 400 million contacts you can search and pull from directly.
- **Validation is free and automatic** on every plan, including Essential. It catches addresses that would bounce before you ever send. Bounce rates above 2.5% mean something is wrong with your list: revalidate rather than push through.
- **SEG tagging:** enterprise gateways like Proofpoint, Barracuda, Mimecast, and Microsoft Defender catch cold email regardless of sender reputation. SendKit tags SEG-protected leads automatically during import; unless your entire ICP is enterprise, skip them.
- **Filter before sending:** slice by verified or unverified, SEG provider, contacted or bounced status, or mail provider, so you send to a clean list instead of blasting everyone.

2. Write your first sequence

These rules come from real coaching sessions with customers writing their first sequence, not a generic copywriting guide.

- **3 to 4 lines max.** Every email should read in under 10 seconds. Long emails read as a template.
- **No links in email one.** With no relationship yet, a link adds suspicion and spam risk. Links belong in email two onward.
- **No bold, no highlights.** Plain text reads like a person. Formatted text reads like a campaign, and both filters and prospects notice.
- **PS instead of unsubscribe link.** A formal unsubscribe link is a spam signal in cold email. "PS: reply stop and I'll take you off the list" does the same job.
- **Personalize with variables** like {{firstName}}, {{company}}, or {{painPoint}}, plus sender-based and context-based variables such as a "Happy Monday" line that swaps in by send day.
- **One-click spintax** generates wording variations so every email looks distinct, which matters for spam filters and copy fatigue.
- **The question-mark follow-up.** A single short question usually outperforms a full re-pitch: it lowers the bar to reply and reads like a real nudge.
- The sequence builder has an **Open in Claude** button, so you can hand a draft to Claude for a copy pass without leaving the platform.

3. Launch and read the sending schedule

- **"Start now" does not blast.** It queues sends across today and tomorrow around each lead's mapped timezone, your daily caps, and campaign priority. Nothing sends outside a lead's working hours; a lead whose business hours have passed queues for their tomorrow morning.
- **Volume caps:** 15 cold emails per mailbox per day, up to 20 once a mailbox has warmed for about two weeks.
- **Check the dashboard after launch.** It shows today versus tomorrow volumes per campaign plus reply stats (positive, neutral, bounce) over 7, 30, 90 days, or all-time. A low today number usually just means most leads' business hours have passed.
- **Campaign priority is the only lever** when campaigns share mailboxes. Set high or low and the sending algorithm splits daily volume accordingly, giving a hot-list campaign first claim while an older campaign fills in around it.

PRE-LAUNCH CHECK, THIRTY SECONDS

List imported and validated, SEG-protected leads skipped, sequence at 3 to 4 lines with no links in email one, settings on auto, priority set if mailboxes are shared. If all five hold, hit start now.